The Mihai Eminescu Trust

www.mihaieminescutrust.org

NEWSLETTER 2008

The Trust had another outstanding year in 2008. A highlight was the re-consecration of the beautiful Saxon church in Floresti and the return of its 15th century altarpiece. Bishop Klein, Head of the Lutheran Church, took the service with Dechant Bruno Froehlich, Diacon Joachim Lorenz and the village's Orthodox priest. The Sighisoara choir sang and the church was so full that many had to stand at the back, there being no room left on the 50 newly-carved benches. After the ceremony, Mr and Mrs Harbada, Directors of MET Floresti, generously provided a village feast for 150 guests. Originally built by Antonius and Markus Bethlen in the 15th century, the church bears a plaque in their honour on the east wall. The present tower dates from 1835 and has a roof with a pyramid form. The exterior stone walls are supported by buttresses, and there is an interior balcony and pulpit. Over five years many craftsmen and architects contributed to the exterior and interior restoration of the church; among them were the MET's late architect Gabriel Lambescu, Vasile Vranceanu from Malancrav, Florin Cosorean from Floresti, conservation architect Jan Huelsemann, UK master stonemason Henry Rumbold and many others.





THE WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT

Viscri area: In the villages of **Bunesti, Cloasterf, Crit, Mesendorf, Saschiz, Drauseni** and **Viscri**, we worked on 46 restoration projects. Repairs continued on the fortified walls and the roof of the Bunesti church. A new wooden fence and gate were built around the Evangelical Church in Viscri. A pilot project to make water troughs from poplar trees and to repair old barns in the lower, more humid part of the village, has started with funds from Horizon Foundation. With the generous support of HRH The Prince of Wales, the MET launched a project to introduce ecological sanitation in Viscri. The sewage treatment, involving reed beds and artificial wetlands, has not previously been implemented in Romania on the scale of a whole village. Based on the technical documentation produced for the MET by engineers from M&R Impex from Ploiesti, we were able to obtain all necessary permits and work on building the pipe system has started.

Malancrav area: Here we implemented 31 projects. In **Malancrav** itself 16 houses were restored, including general repairs and interior renovation of the Catholic parish house. We also repaired the roof of the Saxon church, helping to prevent humidity from damaging the valuable 14th century frescoes, and installed a new septic tank at the Evangelical preacher's house. One of the most important achievements was the completion of our second brick-and-tile kiln, with financial support from Horizon Foundation, which will provide much-needed handmade traditional materials to restoration projects in Transylvania. We also equipped a carpentry workshop, to be used by a local craftsman for training and production of traditional windows, shutters, doors and gates. In **Floresti**, as well as 13 restoration projects, we carried out interior painting and furnishing at the Evangelical church and roof and exterior repairs at the Orthodox church. We also improved one of the bridges in the village.

Alma Vii/Mosna area: With a generous donation from the Planet Foundation and a grant from Horizon Foundation, we were able to expand our Whole Village Project in the Mosna commune, near Medias, particularly in the beautiful village of Alma Vii. Our team of local craftsmen, led by Iosif Vuca, established their own small business and continued their on-the-job training in traditional building skills by restoring one of the oldest buildings in Mosna. This complex project offered a variety of training opportunities, from masonry and plaster restoration to roof repairs and building a new wooden terrace. The team also rebuilt three wooden bridges in Alma Vii and started the restoration of a lovely facade in the centre of the village. In addition we signed a contract with a young building expert who has recently moved to Alma Vii, Florin Opris, to execute emergency repair works on the old school, which will be restored and converted into a heritage information centre. At the request of the local town hall, the MET also funded feasibility studies for ecological sanitation and water supply systems in Alma Vii. In November the community of Mosna celebrated ten years since HRH The Prince of Wales visited their village, and the MET conveyed the Prince's warm regards.

OTHER VILLAGES

In **Apold** local coordinator Sebastian Bethge rebuilt the traditional arched gate of the Evangelical parish house, with the help of a German Journeyman, and consolidated the cellar and walls of farm house no. 248. As part of the landscape conservation initiative *Green Trappold*, supported by the MET, the team also started an after-class environmental and waste education programme with local school children.

Work continued on the old mill in **Hosman**, where the Cotaru family and their colleagues, Luiza and Domokos Boldizsar, plan to open a bakery. A room was built to accommodate the large bread oven; several milling machines – such as the wheat mill and the sieves – have been repaired or bought; and the old street-facing windows are being restored by Stefan Vaida. The double facade of house no. 191 was restored with the help of the owners, while work started on a new traditional guesthouse at no. 163.

House no. 92 in **Altana** has undergone major conservation works, including masonry, plaster and window repairs. In the course of restoration, several old inscriptions were uncovered.

In the Hungarian village **Bikfalva** (Bicfalau) we helped set up an independent heritage conservation initiative led by art historian Reka Varallyay.

Our architect Jan Huelsemann and the team of our expert restoration craftsman, Ernst Linzing from Malancrav, worked on the fortified church in **Axente Sever**, as part of a large project coordinated by Operation Villages Roumains from The Netherlands and ProDenkmal from Germany.

EIGHT SAXON FORTIFIED CHURCHES

In cooperation with the Leitstelle Kirchenburgen project of the Lutheran Church, the MET's architects produced feasibility studies for the restoration of eight Saxon fortified churches in Transylvania, including Mesendorf, Crit, Cloasterf, Malancrav and Apold. Together with ten other churches, these have been proposed for restoration in a joint application for EU funds. Should the application be successful, the MET will be a partner in the project, in charge of coordinating and supervising some of the restoration works.

SUSTAINABLE TOURISM

Greenways: The MET launched a project to include the Saxon villages in Europe's Greenways initiative, with support from the Romanian Environmental Partnership Foundation and Vodafone. The aim is to encourage enjoyment of Transylvania's heritage at close quarters, by transportation without cars or buses, whether by walking, riding, horse-drawn cart or cycling. Information about sites of special interest, accommodation and local guides can be found on the website www.saxongreenway.ro.



The project involved education and promotion with school children from Sighisoara, roundtables with local mayors, the publication and distribution of Saxon Greenway leaflets in four languages, the installation of information panels (in Sighisoara, Danes and Bradeni) and more than 20 route markers.

Inntravel: The Trust's guesthouses in the Saxon villages have been included in the 2009 worldwide catalogue of the prestigious UK tour operator Inntravel (www.inntravel.co.uk), which is promoting Romania as its top new destination next

year. The MET and Inntravel worked together to prepare an exciting week-long holiday for groups of up to eight people, combining accommodation in historic village guesthouses in Viscri, Crit, Malancrav and Biertan, walks and horse cart trips among Transylvania's rich forests and meadows, and visiting mediaeval World Heritage citadels.

SYNAGOGUE

The MET supported some of the restoration works done by Mr David Blum and Fundatia Ariel at the Jewish synagogue in Sighisoara, as well as a number of cultural events and publications aimed at raising awareness among locals and visitors about the history, culture and arts of Transylvania's Jewish communities. Erich Raducan, known as the last Jew of Sighisoara, who cared for the synagogue, sadly died on the 8th of October. Our architect Letitia Cosnean and project manager Julie Dawson are now working on the restoration of the beautiful and much larger Medias Synagogue.



Medias Synagogue

SIBIU – AGNITA RAILWAY

After years of lobbying, fundraising and negotiations, the Sibiu – Agnita Development Consortium was established in February, with the goal of restoring and reopening the old narrow gauge railway. Comprising local authorities from the route of the railway, the Consortium obtained a 25-year lease of the line, enabling it to apply for EU funds to implement the major repair works needed. The old engines and carriages in Sibiu were in danger, as their owner – the Railway Tourism Company SFT – had decided to sell them for scrap. With the MET's financial support, however, the Consortium managed to save four of the original carriages – the last narrow gauge passenger carriages in the country – which are now being cleaned by the Friends of the SAR Association. For more details see www.sibiuagnitarailway.com

APAFI MANOR

The Apafi Manor had a wide range of visitors throughout the year. In early spring, Emma Keswick brought a group of friends to walk in the hills and said it was "the perfect holiday". Top CondeNast journalist Gully Wells, who came to write about the area, said: "That really was one of the most enjoyable and interesting of my many voyages around the world, and all thanks to the Trust". A group of 24 from the Irish Tree Society enjoyed lunch there in late May, and the Trust's patron, HRH the Prince of Wales, visited the same month. Two Romanian weddings were celebrated in the house and garden, while nine musicians playing in the village used the Manor as their base. After his visit, David Campbell, publisher of Everyman's Library, donated a very large consignment of classics in hardback and persuaded Penguin, Random House and Weidenfeld to donate everything they have of fiction or history on Central Europe. We are extremely grateful. In late July the tranquillity of the Manor provided an ideal setting for the Bucharest-Princeton University five-day seminar in early modern philosophy.

EU LEONARDO PROGRAMME

After the success of the Leonardo Training Project last year, a team of building restoration craftsmen from Shropshire and Herefordshire returned to Viscri under the leadership of Colin Richards (conservation officer at South Shropshire Council). The specialists, using hand tools and locally available materials, divided into three teams and worked alongside local builders. The first group raised an old barn that had sunk into a marsh at the edge of the village, and repaired its broken timbers. The second group worked on the fortifications of the medieval church at Bunesti, rebuilding a collapsed defensive tower and uncovering a secret tunnel leading from the battlements to the church. The third group undertook an archaeological dig below the walls of the Sighisoara citadel. The skills demonstrated taught the principles of conservation to local builders and to carpentry students from Hereford College of Technology. The value of these visits is not only the exchange of expertise, but also the friendship that is developed between the UK visitors and their Romanian hosts. The MET would like to thank everyone who took part in this remarkable project.

NATURE, FLORA, FAUNA AND ECOLOGY

Breite: In May, at a ceremony in the Bucharest Athenaeum, the MET's Breite conservation project received the first prize of the Romanian Civil Society Gala in the environmental protection

category. Over the year, our team of local biologists led by project manager Cosmin Ioan Moga implemented a number of conservation measures on the Breite plateau under our five-year management plan. With financial support from Horizon Foundation, our restoration team from Malancrav built a log cabin as an information centre for visitors and a shelter for guards. With funding from the Manfred Hermsen Stiftung, we enclosed the artificial drainage ditches and monitored their impact. We also hired an additional guard, installed an information board and continued our ecological education with school children from Sighisoara under the supervision of Dr. Tibor Hartel.



Tibi Hartel and students

Controlled cattle grazing with small herds was introduced experimentally on the north side, where plant diversity is reduced. Initial observations reveal that the cattle grazed selectively, leaving the clumps of *Deschampsia coespitosa* (invasive weed) untouched. Moreover, a slight expansion of weeds (nitrophile species) was recorded in the grazed areas, probably because of cow manure. In October, students from Germany accompanied by forestry expert Rainer Barthel studied the condition of the forest-meadow ecotone of the Breite reserve, as part of a research programme funded by Naturschutzbund Deutschland. Their results will help us understand the factors that cause excessive hornbeam growth in certain areas as well as those that lead to a low or high viability of naturally seeded oak saplings. More than 110 school children from Sighisoara visited Breite for various ecological educational activities, under the supervision of Tibi Hartel, as well as 50 other children coordinated by different teachers.

Natura 2000: The MET has joined WWF Romania, Hartibaci Valley Association and other local organisations in setting up the "Podisul Hartibaciului +" initiative, a group whose goal is to bring together the main stakeholders involved in nature and landscape conservation activities in the Sighisoara – Tarnava Mare – Valea Hartibaciului area. The group's first action will be to apply for environmental structural funds to create an integrated management, community stewardship and farming compensation programme for the two partially overlapping Natura 2000 sites in this region. The prestigious WWF will lead the project, with the MET, Adept Foundation and Milvus as main partners. The 85,000-hectare "Sighisoara – Tarnava Mare" Site of Community Interest aims to protect key natural habitats under the EU's Habitats Directive, while the 246,000-hectare "Podisul Hartibaciului" Special Protection Area was created to preserve key bird species under the European Birds Directive. The MET's biologists provided scientific data that contributed to the establishment of the two protected sites.

Landscape ecology: We have established a Landscape Ecology Group, with prestigious Romanian and international members and advisors, to build on the experience of over ten years' conservation work in the Saxon villages of Transylvania. Its mission is to provide the scientists, regional authorities, businesses and local communities with the knowledge they need to manage habitats and eco-systems so as to protect their biodiversity. Activities will include research and studies, volunteering, the publication of information and specific conservation projects. For more details, please see the Natural Heritage section of the MET website.

MET AWARDS AND GRANTS

❖ In June the Trust awarded prizes to 18 exceptional pupils from Sighisoara high schools in the fields of biology and history. We launched these Awards for Excellence in a bid to recognise and support abilities, not only in the classroom, but also in extra-curricula activities. All the winners were invited on a field trip to discover the rich biodiversity and history of the villages around Sighisoara. The first prize winners also received books from their respective fields of research. Through these Awards we hope to ensure sustainable management of Transylvania's natural and cultural heritage in the future, by encouraging young people from Sighisoara to become experts in these fields.

❖ The MET sponsored an issue of the North-Western Journal of Zoology, a highly reputed publication distributed to twelve Romanian universities and museums and over forty international institutions.

❖ A donation was given to the Sighisoara Children's Club for its annual national ecology school camp.

❖ The Trust supported the Peter Jacobi photographic **e**xhibition of the Saxon villages and their fortified churches**,** which opened on the 7th of September in Bad Boll, near Stuttgart.

MET PRESENTATIONS

Between May and November, **Caroline Fernolend – the MET's Romanian Director – gave numerous public presentations and seminars on the Trust's work and the principles of building conservation, starting in Sibiu at the symposium on "Cultural Heritage of the Germans in South East Europe". Restoration of historic places of worship is an important part of the MET's activity. Caroline spoke at the re-consecration ceremony of Floresti church, addressed the Orthodox hierarchy on the occasion of the completion of work in Viscri's Orthodox church, and made several presentations about the Viscri Saxon church and its museum, which is becoming a model for church museums elsewhere. In the autumn, she gave the lead presentation to delegates in the Danube Delta at a UNESCO conference in association with the Romanian Tourism Ministry and the Joint Parliamentary Commission. She followed this a month later by speaking at the opening of the ethnographic museum in Rupea where, before an audience of 250, including politicians and representatives of the Ministry of Culture in Bucharest and Brasov, she received a "*diploma de onoare*" for the MET's conservation of Romania's cultural heritage. With our architect Jan Huelsemann she introduced workshops in Alma Vii and Drauseni and gave presentations in Floresti, Zied, Mosna and Covasna. In September she spoke about the MET's work with to 30 historians from *Studium Transilvanicum*.

Colin Richards MBE – Conservation officer for South Shropshire Council – showed a film at the Romanian Embassy, London, in December, where he gave an account of the interchange of skills in the Saxon villages between teams of building tradesmen from Shropshire and their Romanian counterparts. His son **Joe Richards** also spoke, describing the profound effect the experiences had on all who took part in the Leonardo/Saxon villages training programme. Romanian Ambassador **Dr. Ion Jinga** commended the MET for its contribution to the preservation of Transylvania's rural heritage and for its promotion of Romania's image in the UK.

David Mlinaric – the well-known international designer – also gave an illustrated talk at the Romanian Embassy on *'Restoring and Decorating the Hungarian Manor House in Transylvania'*. Earlier in the year in Malancrav he spoke about his work on the Apafi Manor to HRH The Prince of Wales. The event at the Embassy included an exhibition of black & white photographs by **Arnhel de Serra**, who is currently working on a project documenting rural life in Transylvania.

Noel Malcolm – Trustee of the MET, Fellow of All Souls and Hobbes scholar – spoke about George Enescu at the Gala Concert at the Romanian Cultural Institute on 4th December. As the composer's biographer, he was asked to announce the new Enescu music scholarship which is awarded in association with the Royal Academy of Music in London.

Letitia Cosnean – MET architect – made a presentation to cultural NGOs and regional authorities in Sf. Gheorghe, during a conference on "Natural and Built Values" organised by the Covasna County Council and the Budapest Heritage Protection Office. The event included a photographic exhibition of the village of Bikfalva, where the MET and The Flour Mill's Bill Parker provided a contribution towards the restoration of an old Hungarian manor.



Denes Manor, Bikfalva

George Peterken – the leading woodland ecologist – gave a talk on the Saxon woodland landscape and the MET's conservation work in the village of Kilpeck in Herefordshire.

Jan Huelsemann – MET conservation architect – spoke during the year in Biertan, Covasna, Floresti, Zied, Sibiu, Brasov, Bucharest and Sighisoara about the Trust's work.

Jessica Douglas-Home – the MET chairman – gave awards to 22 South Shropshire conservation

experts on 14th November in Ludlow. She gave a talk at Kilpeck Village Hall in November 7th with George Peterken.

Andrea Rost welcomed many groups and individuals to the Apafi manor, including the Irish Tree Society, singer Peter Maffay, several ambassadors and relatives of the ancient Apafi family, the Szentkersztys. She also arranged two concerts at the house performed by the Aspidistra Drawing Room Orchestra and the Silvestri Quartet.

Andreea Gavriliu and historian **Raul Cârstocea** presented the work of the MET for the international tour company Inntravel at a celebration of the company's 25th anniversary in Gaydon, Warwickshire.

Dr. Tibor Hartel represented the MET at the 39th EUROPARC Conference in Poiana Brasov, taking part in roundtable discussions about landscape ecology and speaking about the Saxon rural landscape to a group of participants, during a visit to Viscri and its surroundings.

Kinga Ollerer took part in the 6th European Conference on Ecological Restoration in Ghent, Belgium, where she spoke on the MET's conservation management activities in the Breite Ancient Oak Tree Reserve.

The internet is a continuous source of information about our activities. For the exceptional quality of our website we thank **David Mallinson.**

Our gratitude to all who have spoken about the MET during the year would not be complete without a heartfelt vote of thanks to **Luminita Holban,** our London Director, who put so many of our events together.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Our work owes everything to the generosity of our principle donor, the **Packard Humanities Institute**. We are also indebted to the Horizon Foundation for its vital support, as well as the Headley Trust, Lord Leach, Lord Rothschild, the Viscountess Boyd Trust, Charles Fisher, Bill Parker and the Planet Foundation.

We owe enormous gratitude to Anthea Gibson for her design and execution of the Sighisoara Tower House garden and to David Campbell for his donation to the Apafi Manor library. We would especially like to thank designer Tony Eggar and woodland ecologist George Peterken for all their help and encouragement, and the Irish Tree Society, the Rufford Maurice Laing Foundation and Manfred Hermsen Stiftung for their generous grants for Breite.

In the villages where we operate, our work continues to be transformed by the commitment of Colin Richards and his exceptional Shropshire team to an ongoing building programme.

PUBLICATIONS – available on request from the London office:

"The Saxon Villages of Transylvania, Romania. A Future for the Mediaeval Landscape" by Kim Wilkie Associates.
"A Study of the Buildings in the Saxon Villages of Transylvania" by Marianne Suhr.
"Exploring Malancrav" and ***"Exploring Viscri"*** two brochures with detailed walking routes and descriptions of places and activities of interest in the areas around these two villages.
"Malancrav. Notes on the Village and its History" by Jessica Douglas-Home.
"Transylvanian Libraries. Past and Present" by Jessica Douglas-Home.
"Erich Raducan: The Last Jew of Sighisoara" by Jessica Douglas-Home.
"Birdwatching at the Apafi Manor House" by MET biologist Cosmin Ioan Moga.
"An Ecological and Nature Conservation Assessment of the Saxon Villages of Transylvania" by Owen Mountford and John Akeroyd.
"MET Guesthouses in the Saxon Villages" by Andreea Gavriliu.
"The Plight of the Saxons of Transylvania and their Fortified Churches" by William Blacker.
The Viscri Calendar 2009

OTHER INFORMATION

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Please send any gift possible to our office: The Mihai Eminescu Trust, 63 Hillgate Place, London W8 7SS, where books, brochures and information about all our activities are available.